

THE BATTLE BELONGS TO THE LORD

TREVOR SUNDBO – PART TWO

Continued from the January 2023 issue

Step 6 – God Is The Decision Maker

If these are not our battles then we are not the decision makers. If the battle is the Lord's then He is the decision maker.

On a personal note, God is saying to me – Trevor, you are not the decision maker – this is my battle, I make the decisions. Your job is to rest in my peace and follow my instructions.

Our objective is to surrender the battle to the Lord, step back, hear His voice, obey His voice and watch His hand move.

"And so it was, when Gideon heard the telling of the dream and its interpretation, that he worshiped. He returned to the camp of Israel, and said, 'Arise, for the Lord has delivered the camp of Midian into your hand.' Then he divided the three hundred men into three companies, and he put a trumpet into every man's hand, with empty pitchers, and torches inside the pitchers. And he said to them, 'Look at me and do likewise; watch, and when I come to the edge of the camp you shall do as I do: When I blow the trumpet, I and all who are with me, then you also blow the trumpets on every side of the whole camp, and say, 'The sword of the Lord and of Gideon!'"

So Gideon and the hundred men who were with him came to the outpost of the camp at the beginning of the middle watch, just as they had posted the watch; and they blew the trumpets and broke the pitchers that were in their hands. Then the three companies blew the trumpets and broke the pitchers—they held the torches in their left hands and the trumpets in their right hands for blowing—and they cried, "The sword of the Lord and of Gideon!" And every man stood in his place all around the camp; and the whole army ran and cried out and fled. ²² When the three hundred blew the trumpets, the Lord set every man's sword against his companion throughout the whole camp; and the army fled to Beth Acacia, toward Zererah, as far as the border of Abel Meholah, by Tabbath" (Judges 7:15-22).

When we look at the example of Gideon, we don't see him at any point trying to make his own decisions, yet he has plenty of opportunity. He looks for the Lord's decision, step by step until the victory is achieved. The victory in our battles will be achieved in a similar manner. When the Lord is in control of the battle, when He is the decision maker, can there be any outcome but victory?

If this is not our battle, we are required to surrender it, not try to fight, not try to make our own decisions. Essentially, the Lord

steps in and says, “Stand down, I will take it from here.” We are still participants in the battle, but we are not decision-makers. This is the area I personally struggle with the most – truly surrendering the decision-making to the Lord, getting out of the way and simply standing ready to follow His next instruction.

The Most Important Questions

How do we know what to do? How do we know what our next step is? How do we know what the Lord’s mind is in our particular situation? How do we make sure that we have the Lord’s mind in the battle, not our own? How do we make sure that we are simply a vessel taking instruction from the Lord and not making our own decisions with our natural minds? As mentioned earlier, there is no room for the thinking of men and women in the Lord’s battle. If it truly is the Lord’s battle, He makes the decisions.

How did Gideon know?

How did Gideon know what to do next? His instruction was to divide into three companies, each with a trumpet, an empty pitcher and a torch. This wouldn’t be a chapter in the army playbook. What happened between Gideon and his servant sneaking down to the camp of the enemy and getting confirmation that the opposing army would be delivered into their hands – and the decision to divide into 3 companies? The only insight we get in the Scripture is in Judges 7:15 – *“that he worshiped.”*

Certainly, there was a great deal happening between Gideon and the Lord in that phrase *“that he worshiped.”* Perhaps Gideon was seeking the Lord with everything he had to know what the next step was, knowing that he did not want to make his own decision, knowing that it had to be from the Lord.

Once again, I will direct the reader to the May/June 2015 Sharon Star article – How to Hear the Voice of God by Andy Snoke. A few points from the article are presented below:

“The intent of this article is to look at a few ways in which God speaks to us in this hour. If you believe that God is speaking to you, I encourage you as a reader to be sure that God is also

speaking in more than one method that will be outlined below. Confirmation is important. Don’t look for just one avenue; look for more than one.”

- God speaks through scripture
- God speaks directly to our heart and mind
- God speaks through godly counsel
- We can hear the voice of the Lord through the prophecies that went before us as individuals
- God speaks through confirmation
- God speaks through circumstances and timing
- God speaks through His peace
- God speaks through the gifts of the Spirit (and related ministries) operating in the body of Christ

As you read this article, please consider the battles that you are facing with the desire to hear from the Lord as to what His instruction is for you in your situation.

Our battles are many and it occurs to me that the Lord gives us a choice. We can fight the battle on our own with our own thinking and our own experience and our own decision-making ability, or we can surrender the battle to the Lord and follow his instruction. The Lord wants to fight our battles, will we let him? Will we step aside, will we stand down and follow his instruction and obey his voice? Will we decide to invest the time and energy to really hear His voice to know what the Lord’s instruction is in this battle each step of the way? We are very good at bringing our needs to the Lord in prayer and to the local assembly for prayer – which is exactly right. How good are we at really seeking the Lord to determine what His decision is, what his instruction is, in our individual circumstances?

Brothers and sisters, we want to get good at this. The path we are on – the path God has for the many-membered body of Christ has many battles to be fought and many enemies to be defeated. Each one of these battles will be won and each enemy will yield to the church of the living God. All of these things are within our grasp if the battle is the Lord’s. †

HOW TO HEAR THE VOICE OF GOD

ANDY SNOKE

Can a man or a woman hear God? If so, how does He speak? How can we know that we are genuinely hearing from the Lord and not from our own hearts? The answer is “yes.” God does speak to His family. And there are ways in which we can learn to discern His voice, over our own thoughts. God does want to speak to His people. When the Lord does speak to us as individuals, it is most often in more than one way. The Lord has a way of “confirming”

His Word and His ways through more than one avenue.

It is important that when we, as Christians, feel that God is “speaking” to us, we look for at least two or three confirmations that this is true. For, as fallen creatures, we can easily be misled by our own opinions, wants, desires, and needs. God’s voice is most often not thundering and overwhelming, but as God spoke to Elijah,

it can be simply a whisper, with other confirmations. To begin with, we need to admit to ourselves, that the most spiritually experienced, well-meaning saints, can get it wrong. We can fully believe that God has spoken to us, and be absolutely wrong. This is the story of Acts 15. It is through several avenues that God's word is confirmed and that we become clear that God is speaking.

The intent of this article is to look at a few ways in which God speaks to us in this hour. If you believe that God is speaking to you, I encourage you as a reader to be sure that God is also speaking in more than one method which will be outlined below. Confirmation is always important. Don't look for just one avenue; look for more than one.

God Speaks Through Scripture

"All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works" (2 Timothy 3:16-17). God speaks clearly, and directly through scripture. There are many things that a person need not even ask God about because they are already outlined in the Scriptures. For instance, a man may wake up very early in the morning and dread going to work if it is an inconvenient and difficult environment. Should a man ask God if he should in fact go to work because it is difficult and inconvenient? I dare say that a prejudiced mind might think that he heard God say, "Just stay home and take it easy!" In reality, the Scriptures teach that if a man does not work, he should not eat. Therefore, there is no need to even ask God about whether it is important to work. Instead, in this situation, a man should give thanks to God for the job that provides the things he needs to support his family.

1. A man never has to ask God if he should love his wife. He is commanded to do so in Ephesians 5:22.
2. A wife should never have to ask God about respecting her husband as she is already commanded to do so in Ephesians 5:33.
3. A family need not ask God if they should pay a tithe to the Lord, as they are already commanded to do so in Malachi 3:8-11.

These are just a few examples of the will and voice of God speaking through the written Word of God.

God Can Speak To Our Heart And Mind

God can and does speak directly to our heart and mind. At the same time, if we were to only rely on our "feeling" that it is God speaking to us, we could easily be misled. This is why it is important that when we feel that God is "speaking" to our hearts, we should also look for other avenues for discerning His will that confirms that. *"And thine ears shall hear a word behind thee, saying, This is the way, walk ye in it, when ye turn to the right hand, and when ye turn to the left"* (Isaiah 30:21). *"For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, saith the Lord; I will put my laws into their mind, and write them in their hearts: and I will be to them a God, and they shall be to me a people"* (Hebrews 8:10). Learning to discern God's voice speaking to our hearts is an acquired skill. It is something we can learn as we mature spiritually. I am sure that God has spoken to us on many occasions, but we did not have the maturity to discern that it was the Lord speaking. This comes with time and experience. *"For every one that useth milk is unskilful in the word of righteousness: for he is a babe. But strong meat belongeth to them that are of full age, even those who*

by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil" (Hebrews 5:13-14). *"Verily, verily, I say unto you, He that entereth not by the door into the sheepfold, but climbeth up some other way, the same is a thief and a robber. But he that entereth in by the door is the shepherd of the sheep. To him the porter openeth; and the sheep hear his voice: and he calleth his own sheep by name, and leadeth them out. And when he putteth forth his own sheep, he goeth before them, and the sheep follow him: for they know his voice. And a stranger will they not follow, but will flee from him: for they know not the voice of strangers"* (John 10:1-5).

The Lord called young Samuel three times before he recognized that it was the Lord speaking. *"And ere the lamp of God went out in the temple of the Lord, where the ark of God was, and Samuel was laid down to sleep; That the Lord called Samuel: and he answered, Here am I. And he ran unto Eli, and said, Here am I; for thou calledst me. And he said, I called not; lie down again. And he went and lay down. And the Lord called yet again, Samuel. And Samuel arose and went to Eli, and said, Here am I; for thou didst call me. And he answered, I called not, my son; lie down again. Now Samuel did not yet know the Lord, neither was the word of the Lord yet revealed unto him. And the Lord called Samuel again the third time. And he arose and went to Eli, and said, Here am I; for thou didst call me. And Eli perceived that the Lord had called the child. Therefore Eli said unto Samuel, Go, lie down: and it shall be, if he call thee, that thou shalt say, Speak, Lord; for thy servant heareth. So Samuel went and lay down in his place. And the Lord came, and stood, and called as at other times, Samuel, Samuel. Then Samuel answered, Speak; for thy servant heareth"* (1 Samuel 3:3-10).

Let us all pray that the Lord will give us a greater sensitivity to hear and discern His voice.

We can hear the voice of the Lord through the prophecies that went before us as individuals.

In this last revival, which is but a stair step towards the finished work of God in the Church, the Lord in an unusual way has blessed the truth of gifts and ministries to the individual, which are given through prophecy and the laying on of the hands of the presbytery (group of elders). Through the years, we can look back at the multitude of prophecies given over individuals and see that these have been accurate in a miraculous way. These prophecies given over the individuals, as God indicated, have proven to be absolutely astonishingly, amazingly, and miraculously accurate. What we have experienced through the laying on of hands, and what we can continue to experience on a regular basis, cannot be summed up by any word short of "a miracle."

No man can know the heart of man, yet through the laying on of hands by the presbytery (which for safety is always more than one person), truths have been revealed, gifts and power endued, and with much detail, a person's ministry has been revealed. *"Quench not the Spirit. Despise not prophesyings. Prove all things; hold fast that which is good"* (1 Thessalonians 5:19-21). *"This charge I commit unto thee, son Timothy, according to the prophecies which went before on thee, that thou by them mightest war a good warfare"* (1 Timothy 1:18-19).

"Neglect not the gift that is in thee, which was given thee by prophecy, with the laying on of the hands of the presbytery" (which means a group of elders). *"Meditate upon these things; give thyself wholly to them; that thy profiting may appear to all"* (1 Timothy 4:14-15).

If you have had the privilege of being prayed over and set in your

work for the Lord, it is good to review what the Lord said from time to time. God will use these prophecies to confirm His Word. If you have not been prayed over, then please seek the Lord for His timing and opportunity.

God Speaks Through Godly Counsel

"Where no counsel is, the people fall: but in the multitude of counsellors there is safety" (Proverbs 11:14). "For by wise counsel thou shalt make thy war: and in multitude of counsellors there is safety" (Proverbs 24:6). "The way of a fool is right in his own eyes: but he that hearkeneth unto counsel is wise" (Proverbs 12:15). "Every purpose is established by counsel: and with good advice make war" (Proverbs 20:18). "He that trusteth in his own heart is a fool: but whoso walketh wisely, he shall be delivered" (Proverbs 28:26).

"Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God: because many false prophets are gone out into the world" (1 John 4:1).

God has a way of confirming His voice through the counsel of the godly. Often, when we have questions regarding following the will of God, it is good to talk to our local elders, to get confirmation. If we "feel" that we have "heard from God," and are afraid to talk to those over us such as our elders because we are concerned the answer won't be what we like, then something is wrong. Acts 15 is an account of how the new Jewish elders were convinced that the Gentiles must follow the physical requirements given by Moses in order to be saved. There was much disagreement among all; but after they contacted the apostles, and had a long discussion, the Lord gave a clear answer through godly counsel.

When in doubt - ask!

God Speaks Through Confirmation

"But if he will not hear thee, then take with thee one or two more, that in the mouth of two or three witnesses every word may be established" (Matthew 18:16).

After the great debate in Acts 15, a debate that could have split the Church before it had even had time to become established, by godly counsel and then confirmation, God gave clarity. The confirmation was so great, the following letters were written and sent:

"Then pleased it the apostles and elders, with the whole church, to send chosen men of their own company to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas; namely, Judas surnamed Barsabas, and Silas, chief men among the brethren: And they wrote letters by them after this manner; The apostles and elders and brethren send greeting unto the brethren which are of the Gentiles in Antioch and Syria and Cilicia: Forasmuch as we have heard, that certain which went out from us have troubled you with words, subverting your souls, saying, Ye must be circumcised, and keep the law: to whom we gave no such commandment: It seemed good unto us, being assembled with one accord, to send chosen men unto you with our beloved Barnabas and Paul" (Acts 15:22-25). "For it seemed good to the Holy Ghost, and to us, to lay upon you no greater burden than these necessary things" (Acts 15:28).

God Speaks Through Circumstances And Timing

"After these things Paul departed from Athens, and came to Corinth; and found a certain Jew named Aquila, born in Pontus, lately come from Italy, with his wife Priscilla; (because that Claudius had commanded all Jews to depart from Rome:) and came unto them, and because he was of the same craft, he abode with them, and wrought: for by their occupation they were tentmakers" (Acts 18:1-3). This relationship between Paul, Aquilla, and Priscilla, which happened as a result of circumstances, became one of the most important strategic partnerships in the book of Acts.

God Speaks Through His Peace

When a person has followed the voice of God, and has allowed His will to be confirmed by a number of methods outlined above (more than one), then the Lord allows a "peace" to wash over our souls with the great comfort of knowing we are in His will.

"And let the peace of God rule in your hearts, to the which also ye are called in one body; and be ye thankful" (Colossians 3:15). "Peace I leave with you, my peace I give unto you: not as the world giveth, give I unto you. Let not your heart be troubled, neither let it be afraid" (John 14:27). 

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